

We've all seen a million spy movies, drooled over the jaw-droppingly fantastic and equally futuristic gadgets James Bond totes in all his action thrillers besides his trusty old Walther PPK – the character's equally famous sidearm. While we can never fully understand the covert, double lives that most spies lead and the mysterious ways in which they help shape the events of our world, we lust after their techno-wizardry equipped gadgets all the same. We know that's part of their allure and mysticism, that these technology wonders aren't just glamorous good-for-nothing toys but actual weapons (lethal, non-lethal and tactical) that give covert operatives an obvious edge over the bad guys. Take away Lucius Fox's advanced prototypes from Bruce Wayne, and Batman is essentially reduced to just a rich industrialist with

the mere knowledge of martial arts. What would be the odds of a gadget-stripped Batman taking on the dark underbelly of Gotham, and coming out on top every single time? Not very good, we're afraid. And such is the story of good guys who are equipped to do great things – which are often difficult, complicated things – under the constant shadow of secrecy.

Spying is an oft-abused word in a post-Snowden world. But not all spying is bad, especially if it's at a personal level. For e.g., if you're a shop owner who wants to attach a hidden security camera (not an openly visible CCTV camera, which is different) in your store to keep a watchful eye over the premises, or an investigative journalist (or alert citizen) trying to expose a corrupt politician by covertly video-taping him with a camera and microphone hidden inside your pen cap (nestled in your breast pocket). Such instances of spying or surveillance can actually do a world of good,

and in many cases, deliberate spying sets a precedent and serves as a deterrence to criminals.

In this article, we won't be telling you how to become a master spy or detective. Instead, we'll be highlighting gadgets that are easy to conceal or disguise for the purpose of gathering information, which otherwise would have been very hard, nay, almost impossible to get your hands on. Before embarking on your own Sherlock Holmes adventures, make sure you aren't invading anyone's privacy, trespassing or breaking any law that could otherwise land you into unnecessary trouble. Our only purpose here is to educate and alert, not to deceive or corrupt.

After getting a taste of the sort of gadgets real-life professional spies get to play with, let's take a look at some of the gadgets that most consumers can get their hands on. Time to get into Sherlock Holmes mode, aye?

FROM THE CIA'S PERSONAL STASH

In a rare privilege, just last month science and nature magazine, the Smithsonian.com was allowed to go through the CIA's museum of spy relics located at its headquarters in Virginia. Needless to say, a treasure trove of cutting-edge spy gadgets (with most of their technology still classified) were revealed. Here are a few interesting highlights.

In the 1960s, the CIA's Technical Services Division designed two sub-miniature cameras for photographing documents. They resemble long cigarette lighters, and can indeed be operated with one hand. They used Minox cassettes loaded with Kodak 3410 thin-base film. (For camera buffs: The shutter was fixed at 1/100 of a second and each camera had an 8.2mm f/3.6 lens.) The first camera had a capacity of 100 pictures,

the next generation 200. How the picture capacity was doubled without making the camera bigger is still classified, according to the CIA.

During the Vietnam War, according to the same Smithsonian article, the CIA recruited Laotian trail watchers to count troops, weapons and supplies moving south from North Vietnam along the Ho Chi Minh trail. Agency technical experts developed a hand-held counter for them called 'HARK'. It was about the size of a present day tablet and could transmit data to an airplane overhead.

But since many of the watchers could neither read nor write, the CIA technicians used icons to represent soldiers, weapons, vehicles and even elephants.



Then there's this dragonfly-sized eavesdropping bug, which was quite ingenious for its time. Here's what Smithsonian tells us about

it: Developed by CIA's Office of Research and Development in the 1970s, this micro unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) was the first flight of an insectohtopter (an insect-sized vehicle). It was intended to prove the concept of such miniaturized platforms for intelligence collection. The Insectohtopter had a miniature engine to move the wings up and down. A small amount of gas was used to drive the engine, and the excess was vented out the rear for extra thrust. The flight tests were impressive. However, control in any kind of crosswind proved too difficult.

To read the rest of the Smithsonian article on CIA artefacts, go here: dgit.in/SmithSpy

